victorious return of the army to the same grounds which they had left three years earlier. There were twenty-one-gun salutes for Sale, Pollock and Nott, and even one for the supposed Somnath Gates which were brought into camp covered in marigold garlands. A succession of banquets were then laid on in vast shamiana marquees, though many had little appetite for such festivities after what they had just gone through. Mackenzie retired to his tent, writing that few 'felt anything like the joy which might have been anticipated . . . All the [former] captives suffered from depression of spirits, some of them, as Eyre, to a terrible degree. Some of the ladies dreamt of the horrors they had witnessed night after night for months after their release.'[123]

Also disenchanted with all the junketing was the Commander-in-Chief, Sir Jasper Nicholls. After watching the troops march in for a while he returned to his desk to begin drawing up his official report on how his army had suffered such an unparalleled disaster. 'I would not have counselled that invasion *for any honour* which could have been conferred on me,' he wrote.[124] After all the waste and destruction of an expensive and unnecessary war of dubious legality, with the honour and reputation of British arms tarnished and British authority undermined; after spending £15 million [well over £50 billion in modern currency], exhausting the Indian treasury, pushing the Indian credit network to the brink of collapse and permanently wrecking the solvency of the East India Company; after losing maybe 40,000 lives, as well as those of around 50,000 camels; and after alienating much of the Bengal army, leaving it ripe for mutiny, the British had left Afghanistan much as they found it, he concluded: in tribal chaos, with Dost Mohammad about to return from exile and on the verge of retrieving his throne. Just ahead of the troops, the news had just come in by express that both Prince Safdarjang in Kandahar and Prince Shahpur in Kabul had been forced out by their Barakzai enemies.

In truth, no one except the bombastic Governor General himself was convinced by Ellenborough's claims of victory, least of all the Afghans. As Mirza 'Ata put it: 'The remaining troops when they were safely out of Afghanistan were welcomed by speeches by the Governor General: for the proverb says Afghanistan is the land of hawks, but India is a land of carrion crows?. . .' He continued:

> It is said that the English entered Afghanistan a second time merely to free the English prisoners, spending lakhs and lakhs to bribe the Afghans into allowing them passage, leaving